

Severe bleeding: stop the bleed

Most bleeding you will see is minor and stops on its own or with a little pressure. But bleeding that is **spurting, pooling, soaking through clothing or bandages, or coming from a deep wound to an arm or leg** can be life-threatening. The single most important thing you can do is press hard on the wound and not let up.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES

Life-threatening bleeding is an emergency

Call your local emergency number (for example 911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK), or have someone else call, for spurting blood, pooling blood, bleeding that soaks through clothing/bandages, an amputation, or any heavy bleeding you are worried about. If you are alone, it is reasonable to **start pressure first** and call as soon as you can — put the phone on speaker and follow dispatcher instructions. Get yourself safe first if there is traffic, fire, weapons, or other danger.

Three actions that stop bleeding

If you have gloves or any barrier (a plastic bag can help), use them to protect yourself from blood. If no barrier is available and the bleeding is life-threatening, do the best you safely can and wash thoroughly afterward. Find where the blood is coming from — you may need to move or cut away clothing to see the wound clearly.

- 1 Press hard with both hands.** Place a clean cloth, gauze, or your protected hands directly on the wound and push down as hard as you can, right on the spot the blood is coming from. Keep steady, firm pressure — do not lift up to check unless a dispatcher or trained responder tells you to. Many serious bleeds slow or stop when pressure is applied firmly enough and held long enough.
 - 2 If it keeps bleeding, pack the wound.** For a deep wound in a place you can pack — an arm, leg, armpit, or groin (*not* the chest, abdomen, neck, or head) — push clean gauze or cloth firmly all the way into the wound, filling it completely, then press down hard over the top with both hands and keep pressing.
 - 3 For a limb that won't stop, use a tourniquet.** If heavy bleeding from an arm or leg does not stop with pressure and packing, or the injury is an amputation/near-amputation, apply a tourniquet (see below) if one is available or you are trained to improvise. For life-threatening limb bleeding, tourniquets can be the right choice — follow local training and dispatcher instructions.
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How to use a tourniquet

FOR ARMS AND LEGS ONLY

Use a manufactured tourniquet if you have one. Improvised tourniquets are harder to make effective and can injure tissue; use one only when life-threatening limb bleeding cannot be controlled another way and no manufactured tourniquet is available. Avoid thin cord or rope because it can cut the skin.

- 1 **Place it 5–7 cm (2–3 inches) above the wound**, between the wound and the heart. Do not place it directly over a joint (knee or elbow) — go above the joint if needed. Never put it on the wound itself.
- 2 **Pull it tight and tighten until the bleeding stops.** A tourniquet that is tight enough to work will hurt — that is expected. If one is not enough to stop the bleeding, apply a second one just above the first.
- 3 **Note the time** you put it on (write it on the tourniquet, tape, or a visible note if you can) and tell the medics. **Do not loosen or remove it** — leave that to medical professionals.

While you wait for help

KEEP PRESSURE AND WATCH FOR SHOCK

- **Keep pressing** the whole time, even once bleeding seems controlled, until help takes over.
- Help the person **lie down** and keep them warm with a coat or blanket; heavy blood loss makes people cold and can cause shock.
- Reassure them and keep talking to them. Watch their breathing and alertness.
- **Do not remove an object stuck in a wound** (knife, glass, metal). Leave it in place and press firmly *around* it — pulling it out can make bleeding much worse.

Minor cuts and scrapes

- Wash your hands, then rinse the wound under clean running water and gently clean around it.
- Apply gentle pressure with a clean cloth for a few minutes until it stops, then cover with a clean dressing or bandage.
- Watch for signs of infection over the next days — spreading redness, warmth, swelling, pus, or fever — and seek care if they appear. Ask a health worker about tetanus protection for dirty or deep wounds and animal bites.

Sources

- American College of Surgeons — *Stop the Bleed* (the three steps: apply pressure, pack the wound, apply a tourniquet). stopthebleed.org
- American Red Cross — first aid guidance for severe bleeding and wound care. redcross.org
- World Health Organization — basic emergency care and bleeding control guidance. who.int

- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — wound care and tetanus guidance.
[cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov)

Steps reflect widely taught *Stop the Bleed* / first-aid sequences for lay responders. Training bodies vary in detail, especially around wound packing and improvised tourniquets — follow your local first-aid training and emergency dispatcher's instructions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for hands-on first-aid training, which is widely available and strongly recommended. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Reuse and reprint freely.